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Genevieve Rose

Genevieve Rose first became interested in jazz in 1991. Her story since then has been a publicist's dream. She was 21 years old at the time of this interview and had already played bass with an impressive list of jazz artists, including Dick Hyman, Claude Williams, and 95 year-old saxophonist Benny Waters. She won numerous awards and honors at her high school in Massachusetts, including the state's Overall Outstanding Musician Award from the International Association of Jazz Educators. Genevieve is currently a student at the University of Massachusetts and looks forward to a teaching and performing career in music.

Genevieve was interviewed in Clinton, New York on March 14, 1998, by Monk Rowe, director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive on the campus at Hamilton. I'm very pleased to have Genevieve Rose as my guest, who I can say through experience is one heck of a bass player.

GR: Well thank you, it's a pleasure to be here today. Thank you.

MR: As I was saying before the cameras were rolling, I'm used to interviewing people that could be my grandfather or grandmother, I'm not so used to interviewing someone who could be my daughter, which says something about my age I guess. But it's a pleasure to have you here and I know you've been getting quite a good deal of press lately. How about just telling me about your most recent meaningful gig for you.

GR: Well the most recent one was at the end of February, at the Academy of Music in Northampton, Massachusetts. And we were playing for Claude Williams' 90th birthday, Claude "Fiddler" Williams. He turned 90 that day, with Bucky Pizzarelli also, he was playing guitar. It was a wonderful performance. The place was packed, and it was the most recent gig.

MR: So you had what — 75 years age difference, 74, 75, between you and Claude.

GR: Well 70, right? Well I'm 21 so.

MR: How do you two communicate with that age gap there?

GR: Well I think it's just the same as me communicating with anyone my own age or your age. I don't really find it to be too much of a difference because it's all music and music is kind of a universal language. And the generation gap doesn't seem to really change that at all.

MR: Is there any kind of jazz lingo or phrases that he might use that you're not quite used to at first?

GR: Well I suppose so, because he has so many years of experience in playing in a vast variety of settings. I think that's what makes the playing more enjoyable, because he has such a diverse background and I'm relatively new at this.

MR: I remember, when we had played together, and during one song he leaned over and he said "channel" to me. And for a minute I didn't know what he was talking about.

GR: Yeah, I actually, he had said that one time to me, he was discussing that, and I didn't know either. But then we found out that it meant the bridge of the tune. But yeah I guess that could be a little bit confusing.

MR: Yeah, you kind of just pretend—

GR: You kind of, sort of hear where he's going and then go on with it. But I find that it's a lot more enjoyable and wonderful to play with players that have more of a background and more experience, because I learn more from that. So yeah there's a lot of new things that I hear while I'm playing, but then again I'm learning from that also.

MR: Well what exactly, can you pinpoint what launched you into being a jazz musician? You were born in seventy—

GR: Six.

MR: '76. So the music that you were listening to as you grew up was what? What was going on in your household?

GR: Well I listened a lot to the oldies, '50s and '60s type of music. There is a radio station around my area, it's called Big D 103, and so I would always listen to that all the time. My brother listened to a lot of the current music but I never really did. I mostly enjoyed the oldies. And I think, well I got involved with music pretty early, I was eight years old, and I started with the guitar at the same time my brother started piano lessons. And so really before that I wasn't really concerned too much with listening to music. I mean I heard it but it didn't really hit me with anything. For some reason I wanted to play the guitar. I didn't know why. So I ended up taking ten years of guitar lessons, and it was all classical, classical guitar. I just loved that. So when I was growing up I was playing a guitar. Mostly I listened to the classical guitar music, Segovia, and those. So that's what I had. And then my brother, he did a lot of composing his own music. So I've listened to that. And then towards the end my brother got involved in jazz, so he would play jazz on his radio in his room, different recordings. It was kind of interesting. And I had wanted to play the guitar in ensembles at school because all the other playing I had done was outside groups. And so I wanted to do something in the public school. They already had guitar players in like the jazz band so they said play electric bass. So I had sort of gotten into jazz music that way. And my brother had given me a bunch of blank tapes and he said — oh well, unmarked tapes of jazz music — and he said, "Listen to these."

MR: So you didn't really know who it was.

GR: I didn't know who it was and I found out later, like the first one I had and listened to over and over again was Charlie Parker, Bird, you know, with the tune "Laura" and the strings and all of that. And I thought it was great but I didn't know it was Charlie Parker. And so I was listening to that and listening to a lot of other — I know he had a tape of Thelonious Monk, and then there was a tape of some Billy Taylor playing. So I got into listening to that and I was really intrigued by it, and at the same time I was starting to play jazz a little bit, and when I got to my sophomore year of high school I became more interested with the stand-up bass. First I had started on electric bass and then switched over to the stand-up bass because I saw it in a closet at the music school and I was like I want to play that. Nobody I knew played it. And so it was just from playing that I got more interested in jazz. And I did a competition in my sophomore year where I played, the first time I ever played a solo, and I received an award. I couldn't believe it. So that helped fuel me to do more playing of jazz. And that's really how I got into it.

MR: Let me take you back for a moment. Listening to the oldies station, as you look back on that, is there anything there that you think you absorbed from that music?

GR: Just an appreciation for music and that's for one thing. Secondly I think, I always liked tunes, I figured it out later, that had really good bass lines to them. So I think that helped out. Rhythm you know, they always had pretty good—

MR: Yeah as you listen, and they are very arranged almost. It's easy to hear the form of them and it probably instilled a good knowledge of that. Were you ever tempted to play the chords to "Louie Louie" on your guitar?

GR: Not really. Because I got so involved with the classical music. My teacher was a classical guitarist and I liked that, so I never played any oldies on my guitar or any jazz on my guitar for that matter either, just basically the classical music.

MR: What kind of outlet did you have to perform the classical guitar music?

GR: Well I took lessons for ten years at Community Music School Springfield, so they had recitals every year that you could perform in, and they had combos. I had — one year it was two recorders and guitar, another year it was four guitars. So that was nice to be able to have a variety of ensembles to play with. And also the Connecticut Classical Guitar Society, that was based in West Hartford, my teacher was the Executive Director, Penny Phillips. So I was involved with performing in concerts there and also with the Connecticut Classical Guitar Society guitar ensemble, which had maybe between ten and at one point maybe fourteen guitar players. So I was part of that. So there were a lot of opportunities to play, and also through the music school, I did a lot of volunteer functions. I'd play Christmas parties or background music for house tours. A lot of variety of playing. And I think it was a great experience because now I don't feel nervous doing any kind of performing. So there was a lot of years of solo guitar playing.

MR: This whole thing about becoming a professional, about playing gigs, showing up on time, all that knowing what's appropriate in the different gigs, I think you probably got pretty early then.

GR: Yeah I would say so. Yeah. There was a lot of opportunity for it.

MR: When you think of jazz, what was current, gee by the time you — it must have been early 80s when you started becoming aware of jazz — is that true?

GR: Well not really no, because I didn't start until I was eight and that was in 1985. I didn't really get into the jazz until the early 90s maybe.

MR: Oh, gee, all right. So what's current then? Humm. That's only like seven or eight years ago.

GR: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever get into what, for lack of a better term nowadays is called contemporary jazz, the Kenny G type of thing?

GR: No. I wasn't really involved with that. Because my brother had given me tapes of a lot of older styles of music but I didn't actually go out and actively seek to listen to jazz. Because it wasn't something I was really interested in until my sophomore year of high school. You know I enjoyed it but I wasn't actively involved with it. After my sophomore year, and I started to begin to play a lot more, I was concerned about not wanting to sound like a lot of other bass players. I wanted my own individual sound. So I didn't do a lot of listening at first. I didn't learn a lot of history either. I just kind of like played and tried to develop my own sound. So I didn't listen to the contemporary stuff, not a lot of listening, no.

MR: That was a conscious decision on your part? That you didn't want to become a copy cat of someone else?

GR: Right. Because a lot of people had said well transcribe these solos or these bass lines. And I understand why they say that, it's a good idea to get the style of a certain player. But I didn't want to be copying lines from it. No I wanted to try to bring my own sound to the music.

MR: Well let me see if you can remember the first time you came home from high school and told your mother that you were now going to be playing the acoustic bass. Was she familiar with what that instrument really was?

GR: Oh yes well because I had — well I didn't actually just switch, you know. I didn't say I'm playing guitar today and tomorrow I'm playing bass. It was gradual. So I just kind of played bass on the side. I also played, when I was in high school, a year I did bassoon, I played baritone horn in the marching band. I did a lot of different instruments, and bass was just one of them. And so it was really gradual. And it wasn't until like maybe my senior year of high school that I actually decided that I was going to concentrate on the

bass. Because up until that point I was doing so much guitar work, and I hadn't had any formal lessons on the bass, you know I'd just basically taught myself, so like my technique wasn't really great or anything. But I started finding more and more opportunities. I was playing, I was enjoying it more, and I really liked the style of music that I was able to improvise and put in my own voice to the music. And so it was just gradual. And my mother's been always very supportive of whatever instrument that I wanted to play. And I think that she's happy as long as I'm happy. And I really enjoyed being able to put my own self into the playing, into the music, through improvisation.

MR: How does she feel about you being in these New York City nightclubs?

GR: Oh she loves it. Well she drove me down there so I wouldn't have to leave my car down there. But she is very supportive of everything. And for a long time, when I first started I didn't have a vehicle, she was chauffeuring me to every performance and rehearsal, so—

MR: She was a jazz mom, not a soccer mom.

GR: Yup. It was like her full time job for a while.

MR: I want to ask you a little more about a couple of those gigs later. But did you become kind of — how do I put this — an interesting character in high school? Here I mean you're not that big a person either, and here's this young lady playing acoustic bass.

GR: Yeah.

MR: Were you kind of like this—

GR: Well I mean I came from a very sports-based high school too. So a lot of people weren't very supportive of the music department except for the people in there. But I think they thought it was really interesting. I mean there's this huge instrument and you know I had been doing really well playing, and I also played electric bass in all the Top 40 concerts in high school too, so they liked that, so they liked that kind of music. The jazz was just kind of second for the rest of the kids in the school.

MR: Sounds like you were a person that they were sorry to see graduate, at least in the music department.

GR: Yeah, I don't know.

MR: You became like a valuable person to have there.

GR: Well I mean I was always there. I mean I tried to do everything in the music department. I did the jazz band, I did the rhythm section for the show choir one year, and so I did a lot of volunteering.

MR: Was there a significant live performance along the way that you got to see, or a number of them that heightened your interest in the music? Seeing some well known musicians perhaps?

GR: Well I think what definitely helped a lot was doing the jazz workshops in the summer. Like in the summer of '94 and '95 I did the Vermont Jazz Summer Workshop, and that

was Attila Zoller's Jazz Workshop, and also I did Jazz in July Workshops, Billy Taylor's workshop there. And meeting all those musicians and it was kind of a hands on experience, that really helped a lot. And of course they'd have the concert so you could work with them. I'd say that was a very big influence there. Especially meeting people in person. That was always very important to me. But I can't think off hand of a particular concert.

MR: Well who has become your favorite bass players then?

GR: Well I enjoy music from a lot of different bass players. I like some of Ray Brown, some of Ron Carter's. There's a bass player on one of Benny Waters' CDs, Bob Bowman — no actually, I'm sorry, that's Claude Williams' CD, Bob Bowman. And I basically try to listen for specific recordings that I like. I don't buy them just for the artist, but for that particular recording. Like for example I like Ron Carter on "Alone Together" with Jim Hall. So particular recordings, that's what I look mostly for. And some of the bassists are no name bassists, and I just enjoy the way it sounds or a particular solo. But I look mostly at a particular recording rather than the artist themselves, for a variety.

MR: Is there a gig or a particular series of gigs — it's almost the same question — but that you felt like man this is the big time in the jazz world? When did that particularly happen?

GR: Well I really enjoyed performing last October down in New York with Benny Waters, the saxophone player, at Sweet Basil's jazz club in New York. That was the first time I ever really publicly played in New York City and it was a week-long engagement. And I really enjoyed that. Really nice.

MR: Well there you are at one of the top clubs in New York, with what he was 95 at the time?

GR: Yes that's correct.

MR: And I've heard he can be a bit demanding of his rhythm section, is that right?

GR: I suppose. We had I think it was like an hour intense rehearsal. He rattled off maybe 30 tunes that we'd run through, it was just start, stop, start, stop, start on the Tuesday before we started, just to get an idea of how he was going to be playing, endings and beginnings. But I like that though. I like to have the artist let me know what they want. That's important to me, and still give me a lot of space but I like that, I like a challenge too.

MR: Did you say something about having to sleep in your car that week?

GR: Uh yeah.

MR: I had to remember that, didn't I?

GR: Well actually my mother and I we both, we have a pick-up truck, and we couldn't find a friend who said that we could borrow an apartment for a night to stay in, and we couldn't find a parking spot anywhere near. And finally it got to be like the only parking spots were so far away we didn't think it would be safe to walk to the — so we ended up

driving out of the city, up past like Yonkers and we found a side street and we just kind of camped out in the back. It was very cold.

MR: That's going to be a great story when we do this next interview like twenty, thirty years from now, you can talk about your first gig in New York and you had to sleep in your car.

GR: It was worth it though. It was freezing but it was worth it.

MR: No kidding. I wonder what your mother was thinking — what have we gotten into here?

GR: Oh I think she — an adventure you know. It was eventful I think. It was great.

MR: Was she there for the gigs?

GR: She stayed the first time and then came for the last night. So it was great. She is very supportive and I think that's very important.

MR: You had mentioned that you've won about — it sounds like a batting average here — 20 consecutive "Most Valuable Player" awards in these high school festivals.

GR: Right. At school every year we do maybe six competitions, that type of thing. And since my sophomore year, to my senior year, the first one in my sophomore year, I received an MVP, 20 of them, yeah. So it was great. It really helps. It was a positive reinforcement for me to keep playing and trying harder with the music because you know I'd get done with a competition and I'd say oh that was a terrible solo, or this or that, very self critical, and then I'd get an award and I guess well it wasn't that bad, I'll have to keep trying more and more. And so that really helps. I think it's really important, especially in an educational institution like that, to be able to have positive reinforcement. And it definitely helped me out. Because I would be playing guitar right now if I didn't have that, if I didn't have someone there to say you are doing well and keep going on the right track.

MR: Well it's good that you also look at it as a push to improve yourself that you could almost say well gee I'm just winning all these awards, I can just stay the way I am.

GR: Yeah but no it's not like that.

MR: It doesn't sound like you from what I can tell. You've gotten to play with Dick Hyman and Dave Grusin, was this workshops?

GR: This was a workshop, yeah, this is one I did last year, last summer at the Henry Mancini Institute. It was a month long. It was great. I got to meet a lot of wonderful musicians, Bob Mintzer was there. There was a whole philharmonic. So it was the first year that they had the workshop. And I thought it was a great, wonderful workshop, to be able to meet — just like the Jazz in July and the Vermont Summer Workshop, being able to meet top people in the field, and being able to perform along with them. And so they had a philharmonic, they had a big band and orchestra, small groups.

MR: Do you have a business card?

GR: Well I moved and I have to get one.

MR: I'm just curious because it's interesting, as you meet all these people, I'm wondering if you look into the future and say I would like this person to have my name, because you never know. So are you the type — are you a self promoter somewhat?

GR: I always try to give out some kind of card. For a while I had ones where I had my picture on the side you know, something different, with the bass. I've always tried to let — well let me see how would I say that —

MR: Let the music speak for itself.

GR: Yeah. The music speak for itself. Yeah, I guess that's the best way to play it.

MR: I suppose. But your attitude towards I think the gigs is also important too, that from the playing we've done together I know that you're always on time, you always want to look the part, and people notice that.

GR: I always enjoy every one too.

MR: Tell me about where your education is right now in music and how you feel about it.

GR: Well I'm going to U Mass, the University of Massachusetts Amherst and I'm in my junior year, although I probably have about a few more years left because I'm doing a double major in music education and jazz performance. And I'm also taking like the minimum amount of full time each semester now. My first two years I kind of tried to — I thought I would get done in four years and so I took 20, 21 credits, and it was just too much. So now I'm down to 12 or 15 credits, so that I can do my performing on the outside, the gigs at night. So I'm trying to build up my career and contacts while I'm still in school so that I'll have something for when I get out, rather then a lot of students, they try to wait until they get out of school and then say well then I'll go run down to New York or try to make a name, or I don't know. But I think it's better to just build them up gradually at the same time so that I'll have work for when I get out of school. And eventually I'd like to teach, maybe at the high school or university level.

MR: Do you feel you have to go to New York to — well you've already been to New York.

GR: I think Western Mass is a very nice — it's very convenient to New York and to Boston and upstate New York. So it's a very central location and I like it. And I think I'd just be happy just to commute to any job I get down there.

MR: So are you telling me that you don't see a future as a full time jazz musician for yourself?

GR: Well I would like to, but eventually I'd like to teach. But also do a lot of playing. That's why I'd like, maybe at the university level, because then there's less — you can leave.

MR: You have to be there 3-1/2 days a week.

GR: Well you know like public high school, originally I was thinking about that, but it's a big time commitment.

MR: It sure is.

GR: You know you have marching band after school, and I still want to be able to continue performing and playing. Because you have to keep up with it, you can't just—

MR: We've talked with a number of, actually a lot of musicians who are mostly self-taught, because when they were growing up there was not jazz education. Do you feel that your experience and your classmates' experience is enough to make them be able to function in the real world of jazz music?

GR: Well I think the classroom is part of it maybe. But I think one of the most important things to remember is like how jazz started out itself, which would be like musicians getting together and performing publicly or anything. I tend to learn on the job if you want to put it. Each gig is a learning experience for me, and a lot of those types of learning experiences from gigs, you don't learn in a classroom. It's like those last minute, and if something goes wrong on the job, you learn from that. It's kind of an off-the-cuff type of thing.

MR: Is it possible to create that atmosphere in the school somehow?

GR: I don't think so. I mean they can also have performances, but I think you have to have a variety. If you keep it always playing with the same musicians too, you know, it's many different musicians, different ages, who have different experience levels, and being able to perform with them, in a variety of different setting. You know there's shows, there's small clubs, big bands, combos, all types of different situations to perform in, or rehearsals. I think that's a very important thing in the learning, is a variety. And classroom is one aspect of that but there's a larger picture that you have to include too.

MR: Do you remember when we played one of the schools up near here and one of the students asked you, "Doesn't it hurt, what you're doing?" Is it physically demanding? Have you ever had any like, your body telling you that this is really hard work, playing the stand up bass?

GR: I think yeah the bass is a very physical instrument, I mean just by the size and the strings. I think all instruments in some way are demanding, whether it's a wind instrument and it's air capacity and all that. I mean I've had problems, I had played a very large seven-eighths bass for a while, and my hand just isn't that big. And it had a very high action, and I injured my hand and for a whole year I couldn't play with my pinky. And I'm just recovering from that right now. I mean when I played down at the Sweet Basil's I couldn't use it. It was like three fingers. I had to play a smaller size bass, five-eighths with very low action. So it can be very physically demanding, but you get, your hand gets stronger as you do more playing too, so I mean it's physically demanding but you also get used to it too. The calluses are built up already, so I don't have to worry about that. So just as long as you take it easy, and not play instruments that are too big or set up the wrong way.

MR: Did you ever feel left out because you couldn't spend a lot of time doing your long nails?

GR: No, I never felt that at all, no I never got into that. From the guitar you know, it was always, well a lot of nail work, but that was like you had to make sure your nail was in perfect condition so you could play the concert the next day.

MR: It wasn't so much that you could put the polish on.

GR: No I never got into the stereotypical like junior high, high school type of — nope, to me, music was my focus.

MR: Can you think of some gigs that you've played, this may take a minute for you to think of, but that have been really difficult for one reason or another? Just like wow I'm glad that's done with.

GR: Well I know, we were talking about physical difficulties before, like I did a performance, I think I was called up to do a performance of a Latin band. And I never played Latin music before. And so like the week before, one of the guys in the band said, "Well I'll show you what the bass lines are like." And a lot of them are, like the salsa music is all fifths. So you're using your first and your fourth finger to play fifths on the bass. And I was playing the big seven-eighths bass and I ended up playing a whole night of salsa and merengue and all that type of music. That was very physically demanding. So I would say that was a performance that was difficult in that way.

MR: Also, Latin music, it's very specific what the bass does too. I mean they always seem to be anticipating in some of that music.

GR: Well in the salsa music, yeah.

MR: Did you know that when you went into it?

GR: Well that's why I needed somebody to show me what it was first, because I was like wow. But I was very careful, I listened to exactly what they said, and I mean the gig turned out great, it was wonderful, I did a lot of Latin music after that, which contributed to my hand injury. But it's just paying careful attention. He showed me a couple of different styles of music, some examples, the guy played them on the piano also, showed me the bass line on the piano. So I was able to do that. And I like that kind of music you know. But let me see—

MR: We were talking about just difficult gigs.

GR: Okay. There's been other times when like at first when I didn't have a lot of tunes memorized. I remember there was one job where they had a singer come up and there were maybe 30 tables, it was a big band number, and they were having the singer come up and do some tunes with a small groups, just a combo, a piano, bass and drums combo. And she said she wanted to play a little game with the audience, and that she knew all, thousands of tunes, and they could rattle off a tune and that she'd do a little part of it. And I was concerned about that because I didn't know all these tunes, I'd only been

playing for a few years. But it worked out really good. You know it was a lot of concentration, it was draining that way. The ears were open, and I could see the piano player's left hand from about ten feet away, and so that was demanding. But you know I like the challenge, I like that. I think it makes me work harder, and I think I learn a lot more that way.

MR: That's tough in two respects because a lot of times the women's voices, if they're doing standards, you're not doing them in the standard key anymore. You're doing "Misty" in B flat and stuff like that.

GR: Well another one I think was when I was down with Benny Waters in New York I think it was at the St. Peter's Church, and we did a performance. Cyrus Chestnut was on piano and a gentleman, Vinnie Johnson on drums. And Benny had called off a tune, a ballad I'd never heard of before. And I think there were about three hundred people at this performance. People were sitting on the floor, I mean it was packed. And all of a sudden Benny calls out this tune, he's calling it off, and I have no idea, I've never heard of it before, it does not ring a bell, and I look over at Cyrus, you know, like help me out. So he was really good, he was playing some of the bass notes, and I could hear where he was going with it, and I kind of memorized it. You know we did the first chorus, he took a solo then Benny took a solo, then he had me take a solo on it, and I was lucky just by being able to memorize it. By the time my solo came around I kind of knew how the piece went. I don't even remember the name of the piece. Well that was demanding too, but I love that, I mean that was a great challenge.

MR: Did you ever get in those situations where it's like a jam session and you're playing one tune for fifteen or twenty minutes and all the horn players finally get their thing done, and then they give it to you?

GR: Then the bass solo. Yeah, right. Yup, I've had that. That's fun. That's a physically demanding type of playing. But that's good, I like that.

MR: Well talking about memorizing tunes, do they help you out in school with suggestions, like here's tunes you should know?

GR: Well I haven't really found that, no. But I haven't really taken any — I took one jazz composition class at school, but I don't have any jazz lessons. Like my lessons are classical, and all my harmony has been classical and ear training has been classical. So I find that I just apply that to jazz. So we'd be studying like a Bach prelude or a Bach fugue and the harmonic structure of that, and the ear training, where we'd have to sing and do solfeggio. That's all helped with memorizing tunes. But nobody's actually said, I've never had any jazz classes that say well you should memorize this, or this is how you should improvise. I haven't gotten to that yet.

MR: You haven't gotten to jazz classes yet?

GR: Well not really. I mean there's one improv class that I took but that was more like, it was really basic. This is a seventh chord, or that type of thing. So most of it, my jazz playing has been learning from on the job, learning from performing with different musicians.

MR: Well I kind of made a joke before the cameras were rolling about reincarnation, I'm beginning to think that maybe it's really true. You were a jazz bassist in the 20s and 30s.

GR: I don't know. I love it though. I love the bass, it's great, it's a great instrument and I'm glad I ran into it.

MR: Has there been a process of working backwards with learning the history of the jazz bass for you?

GR: Well definitely, now that I'm doing a lot of playing and obviously I'm interested in the instrument, I love it. Now I want to learn more about it and learn more about different bassists' individual styles. Now do the transcriptions, that type of thing. Well I've already learned like I've started to develop my own sound. Now I want to learn all that history part of it. So yeah I think it is working backwards a little bit. I mean I started into it like playing rather than learning about it.

MR: If I could see your collection of albums and/or CDs, would I get a hint as to what your real favorite stuff is?

GR: Well favorites are always changing too, but I also like listening to a lot of vocalists. One of my favorites is Shirley Horn and I think it's a newer one "You Won't Forget Me" it's called. It has Buster Williams on bass so I like that.

MR: Oh, he's one of the greatest.

GR: And I like one of the discs Benny Waters told me to get, it was one of his, "Swinging Again." I really enjoy playing that one. I got a Ray Brown "Bass Face." There's another vocalist, Larry Brown, "Swing Bean." He's not really that much known. I met him up at the Vermont Jazz Summer Workshop one year, but the musicians on the disc are just so wonderful to listen to. So then again a lot of them are just hearing something I like and then going out and buying that, rather than for the artist itself. I just picked up the Jobim Jazz Masters, the Verve one there, and I love that one. I heard that one a lot of times and I finally broke down and bought it. So a lot of variety.

MR: Have you had a chance to record yourself?

GR: A little bit I've done some demos for other people, not my own, but played on other albums. And I just got one in the mail actually a CD that I had — it's more toward the folk type of music. So a variety. I don't have anything of my own yet, I'm waiting.

MR: Well you've got a few years.

GR: Yeah, I've got a whole lot of time to prepare for that.

MR: Bass players often times complain that the soundmen don't get their sound in the studios. So I hope that doesn't happen to you when you finally get a—

GR: Well there's a lot of variety. I mean like the last one I did it was just a mic on the bass. And other times it's direct. But I'm in no rush to really do my own recording yet, I'm waiting for that.

MR: Do you feel that being a young woman bass player is a help or a hindrance in the world of music. Have you had any indication of that yet?

GR: Not really, not a lot, no, either way. I mean there's been little situations but I think with any musician there's always some kind of block or help. I feel that since jazz music is a very open form of music, it doesn't really make a difference of like your gender or how old you are or your background. I haven't really found that to be the case, no. I've found that I just try to let the music speak for itself and I haven't really found it to be a hindrance at all, no.

MR: Is it ever — I'm trying to think of the word — a little imposing — not imposing, a little threatening working mostly in the world of men in situations like that?

GR: No I mean I just basically consider each musician a musician. They could be blank, as far as, I don't really differentiate.

MR: I know what you mean.

GR: It's just I go by playing. It's not, I mean I don't really think when I walk into a gig, oh well there's a group of men and I'm the only woman, or there's only one other woman. I don't really see that. That's the saxophone player, and there's the drummer, and you know, and everybody gets together and they play and that's what counts. It's making the music, not who's making it.

MR: Right. Are you keeping up your guitar these days?

GR: Well I'm planning on getting back with it a little more. I had the hand injury and so I'm just trying to do the bass right now until the hand totally heals. It's a nerve problem you know, if it got pushed down on the string I'd get a really sharp pain. So basically I'm just doing the minimal amount of playing on the bass that I can, and no extra instruments, just the bass.

MR: I'm kind of always fascinated, when you think of the bass players in kind of the pre amplifier days, how they were expected to drive the part of the rhythm, to drive like a big band. And how were they heard?

GR: Well I think one of the big things that a lot of people may forget about is that back then the bands didn't play as loud, so they would only play as loud as they could hear the bass player. So even though the bass player had high action string, really loud, that style of playing, the bands weren't all that quadruple forte that they play now. They were a lot softer, so you could hear the softer instruments. They didn't cover up the sound of the bass. So I mean every once in a while I'll still rehearse with the string bass acoustically with a big band, but it's not the same because a lot of the time they're just playing as if

you had an amplified bass. The horn players are blaring out and the drum is just as loud, and that's why it doesn't work a lot of time, having an unamplified bass, because the other musicians forget, like they have to play softer like they used to back in the 20s and 30s and 40s.

MR: And when they were backing up singers too.

GR: That's right.

MR: The singers had to hear themselves.

GR: Right, yeah. And recording. If everybody played softer the levels were down farther.

MR: I think society in general is louder.

GR: Possibly, yeah. Definitely. Well Latin music is definitely loud.

MR: If we had a chance to do another interview in twenty years, gosh, what would you hope you could tell me about?

GR: Well I hope that hand injuries wouldn't keep me from playing the bass and that I could still keep doing what I really love and that's performing and playing, and that I've just been enjoying and having a lot of more experiences performing. I'd like to be able to travel around to different places. I know like this summer I'm going to Europe, to Greece and Turkey to do a little bit of playing there. So I hope to do more experiences like that.

MR: Wow. You're going over to play?

GR: Yes.

MR: With whom?

GR: Well there's a group at U Mass, it's called Tradewinds, and it's like a faculty and some extra musicians too, form a little core of a jazz combo, that plays for the chorale, the U Mass chorale. So there's chorale music and then they do some playing on the side. But it's a great opportunity, it's traveling, it's seeing places. I just hope to keep doing what I like.

MR: Right. Are you going to take your own bass over there or do they have to line up an instrument?

GR: No I've got one to take over there, not a good one, but just in case.

MR: Who of the real veteran bassists around these days have you been able to meet? I'm interested if you've met Milt Hinton yet?

GR: No I haven't. I met Rufus Reid for like a minute a couple of years ago at a Massachusetts Music Educators' Convention. But no I haven't been able — I met Ray Brown this past summer at that Henry Mancini Institute. But I look forward to meeting them.

MR: Are there any other women bass players on the scene? I mean I know there's some, but are you familiar with any of them, or does it not make that much difference?

GR: I don't know any personally really. I know of some but I don't know them. But that's not something I really pay attention to.

MR: You just do your own thing.

GR: Yeah.

MR: I'm curious if you've been or seen any of these what they call jazz parties recently. They are gigs that they book a lot of mostly veteran musician into like a hotel, and they have a whole weekend of music. Have you been aware of those kinds of things?

GR: Yeah, I'm not quite sure.

MR: Well I suspect that someday you're going to get a call to do one, that's why.

GR: Okay.

MR: And you can say yeah Monk told me about that.

GR: All right. Wonderful. Thank you.

MR: It's interesting because they don't book bands, they book individuals and then —

GR: Bring them together.

MR: The promoters put together a certain ensemble and you play for an hour and then a different group of people get up. But to do that you have to have the language down and you have to know those kind of tunes that Benny Waters might turn around and say blah, blah, blah.

GR: Right.

MR: Did he even tell you what key you were in by the way?

GR: Yeah, you know I don't remember, all I knew was that I had no idea what the tune was, and so, but it worked out fine, it was good, but it's the challenges that are good.

MR: What was it like to be — we talked about the gig at Birdland a little bit. Did you get good feedback from the audience?

GR: Oh you mean Sweet Basil's?

MR: Sweet Basil's, I'm sorry, yeah.

GR: It was a great audience, and it seemed to be packed in there, and yeah I think they really enjoyed it. And it was good because it was a jazz club, people were there to hear the music. There's so many places that sometimes you end up playing where there's a television going on. But this was, the people were there to hear the music and they enjoyed it, and it was great, it was great. And I enjoy having an audience that's receptive and appreciative.

MR: From a financial standpoint, are you pleased — I don't know if you have a basis for comparison, but have you heard about what the going rate for playing jazz gigs in New York is these days?

GR: I wouldn't know exactly, no. I mean it depends on what kind of gig it was. I mean at a club would be different than — I don't know, what do you—

MR: I'm just wondering if it looks to you like you could make money actually doing that kind of thing at this point.

GR: Well I think the key is one not to concentrate yourself into one specific spot too. Like I try to get out, I did the playing, a little bit in New York, and a little bit in the Boston area, up in Vermont, as far up as Burlington, over here to Utica, I think it's important to spread out, also in Connecticut. So that you have a lot of different contacts. So one night I'll be playing in Western Mass and the next night I'll be playing in Connecticut, and two days later I'll be up in Vermont.

MR: Have bass will travel.

GR: Exactly. So I mean so far it's worked out very well. And if it's enough just so that I can keep up with the instrument, the equipment, a roof over my head and transportation to get there, that's what makes me happy.

MR: Okay. Well I think you ought to move to Utica then. We'll give you enough to pay your gas. Well this has been fascinating talking to you. I wondered if there's anything that you'd like to take an opportunity to say that I haven't asked you about.

GR: Oh boy. Off hand I can't really think about it.

MR: What's the next kind of important gig you have coming up? Any name people?

GR: That's hard to say. I mean I know like I'll be doing the Jazz in July workshop in the summer as a kind of like a faculty member, and I did that last year too, as the house rhythm section for vocalists. And I've got something that should be, I think it's October 17th with Sheila Jordan and Harold Danko as a piano player, and Greg Caputo is the drummer, and that's at the Iron Horse in Northampton. But that's a little far off right now. But that will be one of the first gigs under my own name, so that will be nice.

MR: Well you're certainly rubbing shoulders with some good company.

GR: I enjoy it yeah. It's great. I think it's important to be able to perform and have the experience playing with experienced musicians, I learn so much from that, every performance, so I'm really grateful for that.

MR: Well the music's been good to you and I think you're being good to the music, so I wish you the best in your career.

GR: Thank you.

MR: Thanks for being here today. It was a pleasure, thank you very much. I enjoyed this, thank you.